have had its origins in the Buddhist profession of faith *Buddham saranam gacchami*, ‘I take refuge in the Buddha’.



A terracotta and brick statue of the warrior protector deity Ayyanar near Salem. Similar images can be seen on the outskirts of many rural villages in Tamil Nadu.

The Ayyappa cult may well be one of many instances of the appropriation of earlier folk and heterodox practices by Hinduism. Not only Sabarimala but some of the best-known Hindu temples in Kerala and elsewhere are believed to have Buddhist or Jain origins. ‘In Travancore …’ wrote the author of the *1931 Census Report of Travancore*, ‘most of the appurtenances of modern Hinduism such as temples, worship of images, *utsavams* [religious festivals] and religious festivals were all borrowed from the Buddhists …